- Sanjay Jain, President of the Raipur Iron and Steel Trade Association, explained, 'Demonetization has led to a severe drop in business, which in turn means that manufacturing units are on the verge of shutting down. Retail trade has been hit the most, not just in Chhattisgarh, but across the country… Business has come down to just a quarter of what it was.'
- Stating that 800 participants just in the Raipur association were jobless and currently sitting on piles of stock but no cash to conduct their business, he said, 'People have stocks of goods but there is no buyer or supplier in the market because cash is not available. The full chain is interlinked and if one part stops working, other parts start getting affected too. Even labourers cannot be paid because they don't know banks and don't have accounts. Daily wage labourers work on cash only and if they can't be paid, they won't come to work…There will be losses of at least ₹20 crore in the market every week till the situation normalizes.'[38]

My Perspective

The accounts reproduced in this chapter are a small fraction of the thousands of stories on the human impact of demonetization. They are illustrative, not exhaustive. The common thread running through all of the stories is the sheer despair and desperation that both individuals and business owners had to suffer.

Demonetization did not just destroy incomes and wealth – it destroyed lives.

Daily wage workers and casual contract labour lost their jobs overnight. Their pitifully meagre savings were forcibly impounded. Those fortunate enough to retain their jobs didn't have much choice. They could either accept old notes and then stand in queues to exchange these notes, forfeiting another's day wages, or work on credit, in the hope of a future, but not secure, payment.